



lot of precision. After rumours of Shabnim Ismail and Dane van Niekerk potentially coming out of retirement fizzled out, the Proteas have retained much of the side that reached the final last year. In a team brimming with experience, unheralded 18-year-old leggie Seshnie Naidu and 20-year-old seamer Ayanda Hlubi stand out as fresh faces.

In the 12 T20Is the team has played this year, its form and rhythm have steadily evolved with each game. Marizanne Kapp stayed away from bowling for the first half of these fixtures due to a back injury, but the team showed the wisdom of keeping its eyes on the ultimate prize.

The Proteas leave for the UAE

Early edge: With a pre-season camp in Abu Dhabi proving valuable for acclimatisation, things have worked out quite conveniently for England, led by Heather Knight. GETTY IMAGES

after thwarting Pakistan 2-1 in a three-match series. Over the past few months, several members of the team have stepped up and carried South Africa through crucial phases of play, leading to some memorable victories. An important cog in the wheel will be Tazmin Brits, who has the ability to make or break a game for South Africa, depending on whether she gets her rhythm or not.

Laura Wolvaardt's fluid form, along with Annerie Dercksen and Sune Luus finding runs, bodes well for South Africa, who will hope to replicate last year's success and do one better.

While Kapp remains a force on any surface, South Africa's spinners will be under the spotlight as they look to step out of the shadow of the team's deep pace and seam attack.

Standing in South Africa's way is Heather Knight's England, the inaugural champion of the tournament.

Things have worked out quite conveniently for the team, with a pre-season camp in Abu Dhabi proving valuable for acclimatisation after the event was moved to the Middle East. Coach Jon Lewis tickled the imagination of many when he suggested the use of artificial intelligence in squad selection.

Other experiments were more deliberate, such as giving Nat Sciver-Brunt a chance at captaincy while Knight sat out one of the games against New Zealand a few weeks ago. This simulation exercise, as revealed by the team, was meant to be preparation for any unexpected unavailability.

In the 15 T20Is England has played this year, it has faced New Zealand twice within a few months, coming out on top both times.

A narrow three-run loss to the Kiwis in Nelson and a famous five-wicket thrashing at the hands of Ireland are the only blemishes in an otherwise smooth run leading up to

the World Cup.

Meanwhile, England's spin cartel will be licking its lips. In Sophie Ecclestone, Charlie Dean, Sarah Glenn, and Linsey Smith, the side boasts one of the most exciting and competitive spin units in the tournament. However, its efforts will be futile if England's batting doesn't fire in tandem.

Levelling the field

Outside the cricket field, and as a welcome extension of the spirit of parity championed by the Olympics and Paralympics, there will be a 134 per cent increase in prize money for this year's champion, compared to what Australia earned for its record victory last year.

The winner will walk away with a cheque of USD 2.34 million, marking the first time that the men's and women's teams will receive equal rewards for their triumphs. The overall pot has also surged to USD 7.95 million, a 225 per cent increase from last year. As teams play more frequently throughout the year, and the gaps between traditional powers and emerging sides continue to narrow, there's much to look out for in the UAE. While several teams are already on a path of evolution, others are still rooted in the early eras of the format. This tournament will hence serve as a step towards progression when the teams congregate in the Middle East.

Group A



India
Pakistan
Australia
Sri Lanka
New Zealand

Group B



Bangladesh
Scotland
West Indies
England
South Africa